Module 6 · Workbook answers

Tadabbur (Deliberation)

Video: 26 min **Answer sheet**

This final module teaches tadabbur (deliberation): treating everything that happens to you as a lesson from Allah, and asking, "What is Allah teaching me here?" Lessons you learn help you grow; lessons you miss come back as problems, so this practice gives your whole life meaning and purpose.

Answer sheet: the answers are in red. The reflection questions are personal, so your own answers will be in your own words and from your own life. These model answers show what the session teaches, to guide and check your thinking.

Key teachings

1. **Six practices, one foundation**

   This is the last session of the course, and each module is a practice you can do on its own. Everything is built on the foundation that Allah is with you, Allah sees you and Allah hears you, but reflection from last week can be done separately from deliberation this week. Use whichever technique you need at the time.

2. **What tadabbur means**

   Tadabbur comes from the word dubur, which means the back or the end of something: what lies behind it and where it leads. Allah asks us, "Do they not reflect upon the Qur'an, or are there locks upon their hearts?" (47:24). So tadabbur is what Allah wants us to do with the Qur'an, and the same deep looking can be brought to life itself. Revelation has ended, but Allah is still communicating with us through what happens to us; otherwise we would be walking blind.

3. **Learning to read the lessons around you**

   In the live session he showed pictures and everyone wrote the lessons they saw. A tree: stay rooted and firm in spite of challenges, grow towards the light, and give without wanting anything back, as it takes in carbon dioxide and gives oxygen, shade and fruit. The day and the night: we have limited control, nothing lasts, after darkness comes light, and a new beginning is always around the corner. A mountain: stand firm and stay grounded, life can grow on the roughest surfaces, and you reach the top one step at a time. Allah says that if the Qur'an had been sent down on a mountain, it would have been humbled (59:21). These are the conversations you can have with your children when you are out and about.

4. **"This is what Allah is going to do with me today"**

   A successful business person or parent starts the day with a plan: this is what I am going to do today. A friend of Allah says: this is what Allah is going to do with me today. Everything that happens to you carries a lesson; whether you learn it is a separate point. If you learn from it, you improve. If you do not, the lesson comes back as a problem, and a problem that keeps recurring eventually becomes a calamity.

5. **The man on his fourth marriage**

   A man came to a shaykh (scholar) and asked him to make du'a (prayer) that his fourth marriage would succeed, after three that had not. Asked why, he said he was still looking for true love. He had missed the point: marriage is a vehicle for reflecting the attributes of Allah. Go into it with the wrong idea and the same problems keep coming back. The lessons do not have to come from mistakes; they can come from anything that happens in life.

6 **Surah ad-Duha: what happened to you shapes how you treat others**

The last ayahs of Surah ad-Duha (93:6–11) show deliberation at work. Allah found the Prophet ﷺ an orphan and gave him refuge, so: do not oppress the orphan. He found him lost and guided him, so: do not repel the one who asks. He found him poor and made him self-sufficient, so: speak of the favour of your Lord. In other words, reflect on what has happened to you, then go forward and get better. When you truly live this, life has meaning and nothing is a pointless calamity, because everything is there to teach you something.

7 **How tadabbur differs from tafakkur**

Tafakkur (reflection), from Module 5, is about perspective: you take yourself out, look at all of creation and put your issues in their true size. Tadabbur is different: you look at things that have actually happened to you and ask what Allah is teaching you through them. The guided practice uses three memories: a real difficulty and the hidden lessons in it, seen now with hindsight; a time you were lost or unsure, were patient, and Allah guided you to a solution; and a blessing that came unexpectedly, and the hidden message in it.

8 **A daily habit, and a gift you can share**

Every day you can sit with Allah and ask: what lessons can I take from today? This happened with my child; why did it happen, and how can I improve? Because you are turning to Allah, He will inspire you, and this is especially helpful if you struggle with anxiety or low mood. In grief, remember that when the Prophet's ﷺ son Ibrahim died, he said the eyes shed tears and the heart grieves: sadness is not wrong, but only the connection with Allah lasts. In hard relationships, even if the other person was at fault, the experience can reveal things about yourself. Practise it, even while driving, bring your own dimensions to it (he feels every cell present with Allah), and take that presence into your salah and your Qur'an. Guiding someone else through it is a great gift, and when your children see you sitting with Allah, it is one of the greatest lessons you can teach them.

From the Qur'an and the Sunnah

أَفَلَا يَتَدَبَّرُونَ ٱلْقُرْءَانَ أَمْ عَلَىٰ قُلُوبٍ أَقْفَالُهَآ

Then do they not reflect upon the Qur'ān, or are there locks upon [their] hearts?

Surah Muhammad 47:24

أَلَمْ يَجِدْكَ يَتِيمًا فَـَٔاوَىٰ ۝ وَوَجَدَكَ ضَآلًّا فَهَدَىٰ ۝ وَوَجَدَكَ عَآئِلًا فَأَغْنَىٰ ۝ فَأَمَّا ٱلْيَتِيمَ فَلَا تَقْهَرْ ۝ وَأَمَّا ٱلسَّآئِلَ فَلَا تَنْهَرْ ۝ وَأَمَّا بِنِعْمَةِ رَبِّكَ فَحَدِّثْ

Did He not find you an orphan and give [you] refuge? And He found you lost and guided [you], and He found you poor and made [you] self-sufficient. So as for the orphan, do not oppress [him]. And as for the petitioner, do not repel [him]. But as for the favor of your Lord, report [it].

Surah ad-Duha 93:6–11

لَوْ أَنزَلْنَا هَٰذَا ٱلْقُرْءَانَ عَلَىٰ جَبَلٍ لَّرَأَيْتَهُۥ خَـٰشِعًا مُّتَصَدِّعًا مِّنْ خَشْيَةِ ٱللَّهِ ۚ وَتِلْكَ ٱلْأَمْثَـٰلُ نَضْرِبُهَا لِلنَّاسِ لَعَلَّهُمْ يَتَفَكَّرُونَ

If We had sent down this Qur'ān upon a mountain, you would have seen it humbled and splitting from fear of Allāh. And these examples We present to the people that perhaps they will give thought.

Surah al-Hashr 59:21

> *When his young son Ibrahim passed away, the Prophet ﷺ wept and said: "The eyes shed tears and the heart grieves, but we say only what pleases our Lord. O Ibrahim, we are truly saddened by your parting."*
> **Sahih al-Bukhari**

Practical exercises

The guided tadabbur: three memories

1. Come into presence: Allah makes my heart beat and my lungs breathe; He sees me and hears my thoughts.
2. If it helps, picture the name of Allah above you, sending down a light that fills your body.
3. Recall a real difficulty. How did Allah help you, and what hidden lesson do you see now?
4. Recall a time you were lost, stayed patient, and Allah guided you. What was the lesson?
5. Recall a blessing that came unexpectedly. What hidden message might it hold?
6. Write down the lessons, then take that presence into your next salah.

Lessons from what you see

1. Choose something you see every day: a tree, the day and the night, a mountain or hill, the rain.
2. Ask: what does it do, and what is Allah teaching me through it?
3. Write at least three lessons, as people did in the live session.
4. Share one with your family or children, and ask what lessons they can see.

End-of-day deliberation

1. At the end of the day, sit with Allah for a few minutes.
2. Go through what happened today, including anything that upset you.
3. For one event, ask: "O Allah, what do I take from this? How can I improve?"
4. Like Surah ad-Duha, write one way this lesson could change how you treat other people tomorrow.

7-day practice: tadabbur

Tick each day you practise.

	1	2	3	4	5	6	7
Asked: what is Allah teaching me today?							
Took a lesson from something I saw							
Deliberated on a past difficulty, guidance or blessing							
Kept up an earlier practice of the course							

Reflection questions and answers

1. Which difficulty in your past do you now see differently? What lesson was hidden in it?

> This is the first of the three memories in the guided tadabbur (deliberation): a real difficulty, looked at now with hindsight. Everything that happens carries a lesson, and even in a hard relationship where the other person was at fault, the experience can reveal something about yourself. For example: "Losing my job felt like a disaster, but it gave me more time with my children and taught me to turn to Allah first instead of panicking."

2. When did Allah guide you after you were lost or unsure? What did you learn about Him from that?

> The second memory is a time you were lost or unsure, stayed patient, and Allah guided you to a solution. Surah ad-Duha reminds the Prophet ﷺ that Allah found him lost and guided him, and Allah still communicates with us through what happens to us. For example: "When I could not decide whether to move house, I kept making du'a and waited, and the answer became clear. It taught me that Allah does guide me when I am patient and keep turning to Him."

3. Which blessing came to you unexpectedly, and what message might Allah have been sending you through it?

> The third memory is a blessing that came unexpectedly, and the hidden message in it. Revelation has ended, but Allah is still speaking to us through events; the lessons do not only come from mistakes, they can come from anything that happens. For example: "A neighbour I barely knew helped us when our car broke down. Perhaps Allah was showing me how much a small kindness means, so that I would do the same for someone else."

4. Is there a problem in your life that keeps coming back? What lesson might you not yet have learned from it?

> If you learn the lesson in something, you improve; if you miss it, it comes back as a problem, and a problem that keeps recurring can become a calamity. The man on his fourth marriage was still looking for "true love" and had missed that marriage is a vehicle for reflecting the attributes of Allah. For example: "I keep clashing with colleagues in every new job. Perhaps the lesson is about my own patience rather than about them."

5. How would your day change if you began it with "This is what Allah is going to do with me today"?

> A busy parent or business person starts the day with "this is what I am going to do today", while a friend of Allah says "this is what Allah is going to do with me today". That turns every event into a lesson from Him rather than a pointless interruption. For example: "When the morning goes off plan with a sick child or a traffic jam, I would ask what Allah is teaching me, instead of just getting frustrated."

6. Following Surah ad-Duha, how could something that happened to you shape the way you treat others?

> In Surah ad-Duha (93:6–11), Allah found the Prophet ﷺ an orphan and sheltered him, so do not oppress the orphan; found him lost and guided him, so do not repel the one who asks; found him poor and made him self-sufficient, so speak of your Lord's favour. What happened to you becomes a reason to treat others better. For example: "I was lonely when I first moved to a new area, so now I can make a point of welcoming new families at the school gate."

7. Of all six practices in this course, which has helped you most, and which do you most need to keep up?

> The six practices are presence (Allah is with me, sees me and hears me), visualisation, communication, effortless worship, reflection (tafakkur) and deliberation (tadabbur). Each can be done on its own, so use whichever you need at the time. For example: "Communication has helped me most, because I now bring my worries to Allah during the day. I most need to keep up reflection, as I easily get boxed in by small problems."

My action plan

- [ ] I will end each day this week by asking Allah, "What do I take from today?"
- [ ] I will start my mornings with: this is what Allah is going to do with me today.
- [ ] I will look for one lesson each day in something I see, and talk about it with my family.
- [ ] When a problem keeps coming back, I will stop and ask what lesson I have been missing.
- [ ] I will guide one family member or friend through the three-memory tadabbur.
- [ ] I will keep all six practices going: presence, visualisation, communication, effortless worship, reflection and deliberation, using whichever I need each day.